Playing Hymns Beyond the Written Notes

Lead sheets, accompaniment styles, transposition, introductions and learning by ear.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

In this chapter

1. Read a melody and chord symbols
2. Choose an accompaniment style
3. Move a short hymn into another key
4. Give the singer a clear beginning
5. Find, vary and arrange a melody
6. Be Thou My Vision: choose a texture
7. What a Friend: introduction and transposition
8. Come Thou Fount
9. Be Thou My Vision

1. Read a melody and chord symbols

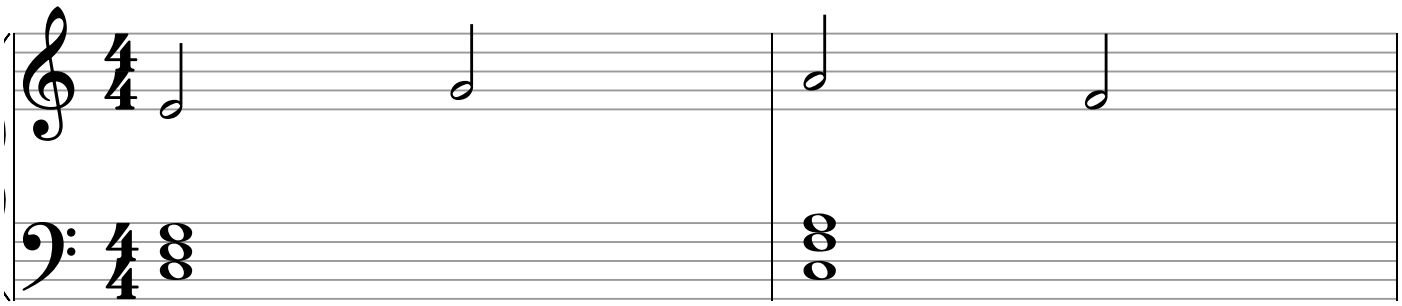
Turn a lead sheet into a simple accompaniment.

Read a melody and chord symbols

A chord symbol names harmony, not a required rhythm or inversion. C means C major, Am means A minor, and G7 means G dominant seventh. First play the melody alone, then roots alone, then choose a compact voicing. The written exercise gives one possible realisation; your offline version may use a different comfortable inversion.

Practise · Read C, F, G7, C

Say the symbol at each new harmony.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Listen and check

Cover the written left hand and play from the four chord names. Check that the harmony changes at the right moment, not on every melody note.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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2. Choose an accompaniment style

Match the pattern to the character and metre.

Choose an accompaniment style

A quiet hymn may need only a bass note and a gentle chord. A flowing hymn can use broken chords, while a strong processional may suit measured chordal playing. A busier pattern is not automatically better. Keep one chosen pattern steady long enough for the singer to feel supported.

Practise · Bass then chord

Give each bar a clear foundation and a soft response.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Flowing alternative

Keep the same harmony but divide it into moving notes.

Listen and check

Choose the calmer version for a singer who needs space. Explain why your pattern suits the hymn rather than choosing the one with more notes.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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3. Move a short hymn into another key

Think in scale degrees and chord functions.

Move a short hymn into another key

Transposition keeps the distances and harmonic functions while changing the home note. First sing the melody as scale degrees: 1-2-3-5. In G those notes are G-A-B-D; the I and V chords become G and D. Work one phrase at a time. Check the new key signature before playing, and choose a range comfortable for the singer.

Practise · A phrase in C

Hear 1-2-3-5, then 4-3-2-1.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · The same phrase in G

Keep the pattern and pulse; start on G.

Listen and check

Before looking, find the first four notes in F. Then transpose two bars of What a Friend using the melody and chord functions, not a fixed hand shape.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

4. Give the singer a clear beginning

Prepare the key, tempo and entry point.

Give the singer a clear beginning

A useful introduction tells singers where the tune starts, how fast it moves and when to enter. The last phrase of the hymn can make a familiar introduction. End with a clear cadence and leave space to breathe. Do not add an elaborate flourish that hides the starting pulse.

Practise · A four-bar introduction

Keep the tempo clear and let the final cadence prepare the entry.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A short Amen

Use this only when it suits the hymn and the setting.

Listen and check

Count an imaginary singer into the next phrase after the introduction. Would they know exactly when to begin?

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

5. Find, vary and arrange a melody

Use your ear before writing an accompaniment.

Find, vary and arrange a melody

Listen to the three-note example, sing it, then find it without looking. Begin with the direction and the home note. For a creative variation, keep the phrase length and change one rhythm or ending. Creative tasks have several valid answers: the exercise checks one reference melody, while your own version is judged by listening.

Practise · Copy this reference by ear

Listen, sing, then hide the hints before playing. This is the reference answer.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · A possible answer phrase

After this example, make your own four-beat reply offline.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Which direction does the opening move?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** Up, then back down C rises to E, then returns through D to C.

Listen and check

Make a short arrangement plan for Come Thou Fount: choose key, pulse, pattern, introduction and ending. Play your own version offline; use the written recital as a model rather than the only correct arrangement.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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6. Be Thou My Vision: choose a texture

Use this broken-chord model, then try a simpler bass-and-chord version offline. Keep the phrase length unchanged.

What to listen for

Use this broken-chord model, then try a simpler bass-and-chord version offline. Keep the phrase length unchanged.

Prepare the opening with separate hands. Then use Play along, choose the hand you want to practise, and loop the troublesome bars. Count the pickup as bar 1 in the loop selector.

Practise · Melody alone

Use this broken-chord model, then try a simpler bass-and-chord version offline. Keep the phrase length unchanged.



Opening example · 3/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Accompaniment alone

Play the left hand softly. Count through the held notes and rests.

Practise · Opening together

Use this broken-chord model, then try a simpler bass-and-chord version offline. Keep the phrase length unchanged.

Practise · Be Thou My Vision: choose a texture

Use this broken-chord model, then try a simpler bass-and-chord version offline. Keep the phrase length unchanged.

Your musical check

Explain which accompaniment leaves the most space for a singer.

Play again without the demonstration. Explain what you changed and whether it sounded better.

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7. What a Friend: introduction and transposition

Learn the written F-major model, then transpose one phrase offline using scale degrees and chord functions.

What to listen for

Learn the written F-major model, then transpose one phrase offline using scale degrees and chord functions.

Prepare the opening with separate hands. Then use Play along, choose the hand you want to practise, and loop the troublesome bars. Count the pickup as bar 1 in the loop selector.

Practise · Melody alone

Learn the written F-major model, then transpose one phrase offline using scale degrees and chord functions.



Opening example · 4/4 · F · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Accompaniment alone

Play the left hand softly. Count through the held notes and rests.

Practise · Opening together

Learn the written F-major model, then transpose one phrase offline using scale degrees and chord functions.

Practise · What a Friend: introduction and transposition

Learn the written F-major model, then transpose one phrase offline using scale degrees and chord functions.

Your musical check

Prepare an introduction from a familiar ending and count an imaginary singer in.

Play again without the demonstration. Explain what you changed and whether it sounded better.

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8. Come Thou Fount

Use the written arrangement as a model. Before the recital, create and play your own short introduction offline; the app checks the reference score only.

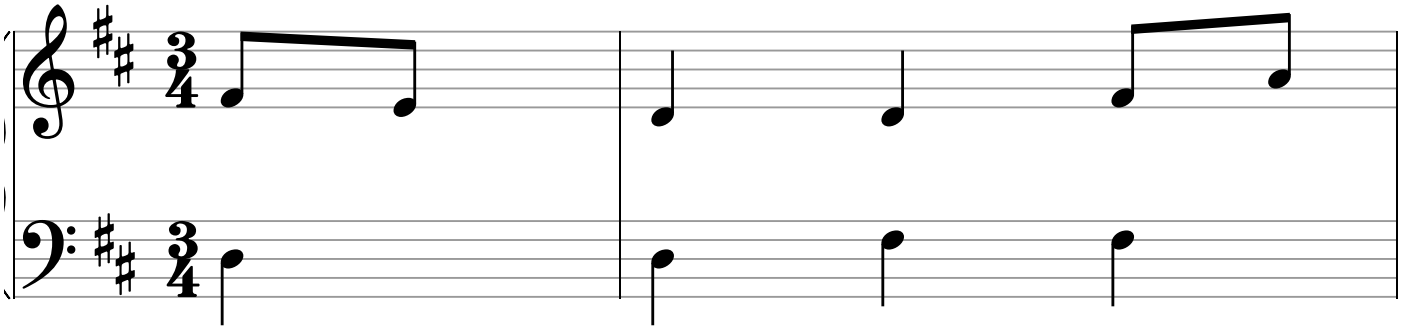
Prepare your recital

Use the written arrangement as a model. Before the recital, create and play your own short introduction offline; the app checks the reference score only.

Choose a comfortable tempo. Practise difficult bars separately, then reconnect them. Make one uninterrupted run before marking your recital complete. Completion records a play-through, not a certified grade.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Come Thou Fount

Use the written arrangement as a model. Before the recital, create and play your own short introduction offline; the app checks the reference score only.



Opening example · 3/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Take a breath, prepare the starting notes, and play through. Keep going after a small mistake. Use the written arrangement as a model. Before the recital, create and play your own short introduction offline; the app checks the reference score only.

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9. Be Thou My Vision

Prepare your own short introduction offline, then perform the written flowing accompaniment with a clear tune and steady pulse.

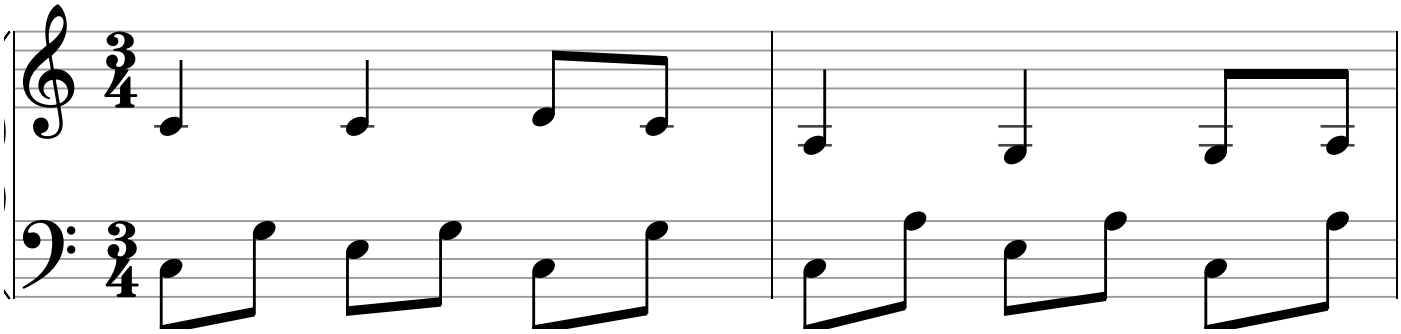
Prepare your recital

Prepare your own short introduction offline, then perform the written flowing accompaniment with a clear tune and steady pulse.

Choose a comfortable tempo. Practise difficult bars separately, then reconnect them. Make one uninterrupted run before marking your recital complete. Completion records a play-through, not a certified grade.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Be Thou My Vision

Prepare your own short introduction offline, then perform the written flowing accompaniment with a clear tune and steady pulse.



Opening example · 3/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Your recital

Take a breath, prepare the starting notes, and play through. Keep going after a small mistake. Prepare your own short introduction offline, then perform the written flowing accompaniment with a clear tune and steady pulse.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Turn a lead sheet into a simple accompaniment.
- ☐ Match the pattern to the character and metre.
- ☐ Think in scale degrees and chord functions.
- ☐ Prepare the key, tempo and entry point.
- ☐ Use your ear before writing an accompaniment.
- ☐ Perform my chosen recital with its stated musical goals, a clear melody, steady pulse and comfortable movement.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
